

Nishiawakura vs Tenkawa: how villages organise owners, coop and operators

Purpose: compare two village-level forestry governance models against Mitsue's situation (no owner group found; coop as owners' body; independent operators such as Tokuda Rinsan, Yamaguchi; owners choose operators individually).

1. Summary

	Nishiawakura (Okayama)	Tenkawa (Nara)
Size	pop. ~1,500; 57.93 km²; 95% forest	forest 97% of 175.66 km²
Who pools owners	The village itself: owners sign long-term management contracts with it ("百年の森林事業")	洞川財産区 (collective property district) for part of the forest; village forest (村有林) and a coop-village-chamber council (フォレストパワー協議会)
Village role	Contractor-and-re-delegator (施業受託者兼再委任者); runs a special account (特別会計) for the scheme	Convener and funder; owns/manages village forest; buys logs from residents for vouchers
Coop role	Executes the work (美作東備森林組合): harvesting, forest work crews	Member of the council; named forestry body
Private operators	Local ventures downstream (processing, heat, media), forestry operators work under the coop	New local operators created via 協力隊 and a youth LLP (2024)
Machinery	Village leases forestry machinery to the coop (rental income flows to the village account)	Not documented
Fuel/heat	Village-linked heat company (村楽エナジー) makes firewood and sells heat to onsen and public buildings; C-grade wood to energy, A/B to products	4 wood-boiler facilities (onsen, nursing home, visitor centre); log-for-voucher loop
Money	Village account, a forest fund (共有の森ファンド, with トビムシ), and since 2020 a forest-trust scheme with Sumitomo Forestry and Sumitomo Mitsui Trust Bank	みらい基金 grant, more trees corporate sponsors, J-Credit, 森林環境税

2. Nishiawakura in more detail

Flow (from the Future City panel): forest owners (villagers) sign a long-term management-entrustment contract with the village → the village entrusts forest work to the coop → logs go to the local processing company (西粟倉・森の学校) for A/B grade products and to the heat company for C grade → revenue goes back through the special account to owners, the coop and the village. The village also handles FSC group certification, woody-biomass use, recruiting and local-venture support (through エーゼロ).

What it shows:

- One body (the village) negotiates for all owners. There is no coop-versus-private contest for the same job, because the village assigns the work under public rules.
- The village earns income from machine rental, so it has a reason to keep the coop viable.
- Wood is graded and routed in a cascade, which is the same logic as the A/B/C routing in the Mitsue plan.

Caveats:

- Facts above are from two government summaries, which are brief. Start year (believed 2008), area under contract, owner numbers and contract length are **not confirmed here**; check before citing.

3. Tenkawa in more detail

Key points (village brochure, 2025/09): tripartite council (village + coop + chamber of commerce), a property district (洞川財産区) that lets one agreement cover a whole area (the more trees agreement, 2021-06-07), and new operators created through the corps (協力隊) and an LLP.

What I did not find: who executes the work, how contractors are selected, or any public coop-versus-private conflict. Village pages are silent on procurement for these programs.

4. Other Japanese models

- 財産区 / 入会林野: collectively held forests. After the 1966 law many were converted to 生産森林組合, and many of those later dissolved for lack of income. Inheritance has multiplied registered owners of some commons up to ten-fold, which makes owner-intent surveys hard. ([Forestry Agency](#))
- 森林経営管理制度: the legal route for a village to pool owners' forests (owner survey → entrustment to the village → re-delegation to registered operators).
- Not found: any compulsory forest body like a Dutch water board (irrigation 土地改良区 is the closest analogue; not researched).

5. What it means for Mitsue

- The Nishiawakura structure (village as contractor, coop as executor, special account, machine rental) is the nearest match to the polder idea, and the machine-rental feature fits the plan to share a harvester.
- It needs the village hall to lead. In Mitsue the village is both the main lever and the main political risk (see the coop-versus-Tokuda question, still unverified).
- Practical first step: use the 森林経営管理 owner survey data (ask Ohba-san) and the coop's member list to see how many owners are reachable through existing bodies.

6. Open questions

Mitsue: any 財産区 or 入会 land? Coop member count and forest share? Nishiawakura: start year, area, owner count, contract length, revenue split. Tenkawa: how village-forest work is assigned.

Sources

- Cabinet Office (2019): <https://www.chisou.go.jp/tiiki/kankyo/miraitoshi/itiran/pdf/nishiawakura.pdf>
- Future City panel: http://future-city.go.jp/doc/pdf/torikumi_city/nishiawakura_panel.pdf
- Forestry Agency, iriai: https://www.rinya.maff.go.jp/j/keiei/iriai_rinyatou_seibi.html
- Tenkawa forestry: vill.tenkawa.nara.jp/office/administration/farm/forestry